

The North Remembers

Part 1:

Kajon väkeä, sinen kukkia

**We are older than all the gods
the dead and the never-born.**

It all started on a chance encounter with starlingdb.org. I was doing some late-night historical research, blissfully unaware, when I found the site. “Nice?! And what a classic look! I’d better go check - these guys do no waste time on fucked-up bling, stalking users with cookies, and UI/UX meetings.” I thought and ventured in, browsing some words in North Asian languages. Then, I spotted this:

Proto-Yenisseian: *ʔoksi (~x-)

Meaning: tree

Ket: ōkś (Imb.)

Yug: oksi¹

Kottish: atči, *atče; (Бол.) аči; acc. аči (М., Сл., Срсл.), аč (Кл.)

Arin: ošče (М., Сл., Срсл., Кл.) "wood"; kus-ošče (М., Сл., Срсл., Кл.) "tree" (lit. "one tree"); otši (Локк.) "tree, wood", otšil "tree"

Comments: CCE 198. The Pump. form oksi (Срсл., Кл.) is in reality Yug. The key to the etymology is probably the Kottish paradigm: atči 'tree', plur. ak / ax, āx. The plural form here undoubtedly reflects PY *xaʔq 'tree, wood' (q.v.). One can therefore suppose that PY *xoksi is a transformation of the original compound *xaʔq-sV or *xaʔq-xusa, lit. "one tree" (a compound analogous to *de-s 'eye' etc.) - cf. a similar later formation in Arin kus-ošče. The transformation of vocalism, however, is still to be explained. Werner 2, 50 <*(x)oksi / *(x)otsi>.

“Hmm! Heh heh, what a funny coincidence.”. And of course, only Finno-Permic people can appreciate this. “I wonder if I’d better run some words thru this database... what would I sense and think if I were transported back to Neolithic? Hmm.” But already, on the same page with “tree”, I instantly found

Proto-Yenisseian: *pōj

Meaning: fir tree

Proto-Yenisseian: *χV-ut-

Meaning: to climb (a tree, a mountain) (quite close to “kavuta” for you non-Finnish)

Proto-Yenisseian: *rəʔə (~-G-, -χ-, -p-)

Meaning: hoarfrost (on trees) (“riite”)

Amused, I thought “Perhaps it is sleepytime because these perceived connections are a bit too easy to find.” but continued instead. After a brief Neolithic RPG session with me & myself and also as a recent father, I found

Proto-Yenisseian: *sūli

Sino-Caucasian etymology: Sino-Caucasian etymology 

Meaning: hook (for a cradle)

Ket: súl⁴ (South.), North. sú:le⁴; pl. súln⁵

Yug: suʔl // su:^hl, pl. suləŋ⁵

Kottish: šūli, *šūle(i), pl. šūlaŋ, šūlān "Haken"

Comments: CCE 279. Werner 2, 213 <*suʔələ>.

And stared at the screen for a while. I did not even have to headstand to see it. It was there, phonetically almost a perfect match, with the meaning similarly off akin to “oksa”. Like a side cognate (if there were not a term before, there is now 8)). I spent a few hours in the database, completely off track from my previous quest.

Proto-Yeniseian: *kuł- (~ *g-)

Meaning: to slide down, to ski

kulkea / liukua

Proto-Yeniseian: *p[u]GVm-

Meaning: soft

pehmeä

Proto-Yeniseian: *pōqe

Meaning: deep

pohja

Proto-Yeniseian: *pɔʔɔle

Meaning: fat

pullea / pyylevä

Proto-Yeniseian: *pəl-se-

Meaning: to sew

parsia

Proto-Yeniseian: *poʔq

Meaning: excrements

paska

It was obvious that this shit needed more research. Next day, an article “Proto-Yeniseian Reconstructions, with Extra-Yeniseian Comparisons” - Sergei A. Starostin and Merritt Ruhlen. Uralic was mentioned nowhere, of course, but the angle was interesting. I thought “Hmm yeah you guys can go south. I have something else in mind. Let’s see if we can make a full circle, thanks for the tip!”

ALIVE *÷e÷te

ARMPIT *qoʔ-

BOIL (v.) *÷ëqan

CRY/SHOUT *(h)uxä-

DIE/DEATH *qò-

DRY *qäj-

EAT *siG-

just browsing for the lulz. “Not bad”, I said aloud to myself. “I need *more*. Where is my next fix?”

It was “Annotated Swadesh wordlists for the Yeniseian group (Yeniseian family).” by G. Starostin.

8. BLACK Proto-Yeniseian *tum- (1) Finnish: tumma

13. CLAW(NAIL) Ket îṇʸ {инь} (1), Yugh iḥ:nʸ (1), Kott halči:g ~ halčix (2), Proto-Yeniseian *ʔi:ne [*xi:ne] (1). Finnish: kynsi

14. CLOUD Ket 'asʸpulʸ {асьпуль} Finnish: pilvi

15. COLD Arin: Dulzon 1961: 187 (M., Dict., Pal., Kl.). Cf. also šil-tʷu 'it is cold', šil-tu 'cold (n.)', maybe also sol-ma 'frost' (Kh.) [Werner 2002: I: 162]. Finnish: kylmä

and then

22. EARTH Proto-Yeniseian *baʔŋ (1). Finnish: maa

I dropped the keyboard.

“ALL RIGHT NOW WHAT IS THIS?? WELL FUCK ME AND MARRY ME YOUNG. TIME TO GET SOME DICTIONARIES AND ALSO CHECK WHAT I ATE LAST NIGHT.”

(not only because

23. TO EAT - Ket $s\hat{1} \sim s\hat{y}\hat{y}$ {сий} (1) / =a ~ =0 (2), Yugh $si^h:y$ (1) / =a ~ =0 (2), Kott $to:p-a:k-\eta$ (3), Arin šau (1), Pumpokol sogo (1), Proto-Yeniseian *si:- (1). Finnish: syödä

whispered “Hey!!! What about me?? I was the next in line!!!”)

It turned out last night was fine and also others could see the row

22. EARTH Proto-Yeniseian *baʔŋ (1).

Fortunately, 23. was placated when I told it that I already knew it because we had met earlier. “Oh right! You mean THIS party?” it said. Confused, I continued on my digression.

After plumbing starlingdb.org, it was obvious that for the time being I had exhausted the Internet of easily available Yeniseian material. Getting physical dictionaries, on the other hand, was a bit difficult, since there were none existing – apart from a recently published “Comparative-Historical Yeniseian Dictionary” by Edward J. Vajda and Heinrich Werner. “What luck!” I thought. They were ~300 euros a piece. “So unlucky!” I thought. But there was one set of the books in an university library in Finland, because in Finland (for the most part...!) we think education is sexy.

Nobody knows beforehand what exactly will happen if the whole population gets a decent education. Some people that know better can of course self-importantly always ask “But, after all, what use is it?”, because ironically they do not know that the answer is “Why, sir, there is every probability that you will soon be able to tax it!”. But better not give *those* kind of people any ideas – they might have an unforeseen reaction to new things.

Finally, I had the books I needed. Thank you Finnish library system! I dove into a world of forgotten languages and for a native Uralic speaker the experience was perhaps the same as with the first native Indo-European speakers finding linguistic connections across the globe. I did not even have to jump through any scholarly IE hoops like

Borrowing from an *adstrate*... or Lallwort?

Borrowing from an *adstrate*... or Wanderwort?

Borrowing from an *adstrate*... or *vrđhhi* gerundive of an otherwise completely unattested stem?

I could just read stuff and later in the day or the next, or after a few weeks (or months...!), understand the connection. Some were obvious. Some were elusive. And some were not there after all. But let me tell you there were and are *plenty*.

Rather interestingly, scholarly FU hoops like

Etymology unknown... or onomatopoeic?

Etymology unknown... or sound-symbolic?

Etymology unknown... or borrowing from Proto-Germanic, but PG word lacks any PIE connection?

were useful to me as “Handy lists of words to check because obviously Finnish is so connected to universal truth that many words sound like the words really ARE in the idea world”. Especially amusing were a general class of “Words relating to winter, survival gear e.g. sleds, or natural phenomena, borrowed from Proto-Germanic”, of course, since those Proto-Germanics are unquestionably the top 1 ancient culture of winter handypersons. If they did not exist, the whole historical Indo-European dominance across every technocultural spectrum imaginable would have a

gaping omission in the postulated skill set! What a disturbing thought. Good that there is a culture that fixed this already over 2000 years ago.

Don't get me wrong, I love those southern weirdos as much as the next Germanic substrate hypothesist (hee hee) but have the linguists making these connections ever looked on a map combined with some weather data for past millennia??? Even my trusty German car *does not have mud flaps as a default* because who needs them in Germany, right? If I were in Germany and wanted to drive in shit, I would have to ram my car through the doors of a water purification plant. In Funland, this is achieved by going to buy everyday groceries.

I don't mind because the late PIEs told us that "Shit is good – you can grow stuff in it and then you can eat it – *no not like that!!!*" and eventually we got the hang of it. But why would they tell us a secret like that? Maybe they have an agenda and Proto-Sámi were right after all... but I digress again. Better paste some more "coincidental homonyms" because I heard it is practically impossible to have many of them betwixt unrelated languages. Everything counts in large amounts. More later when I have cloned myself so I have more time, ffs!

Group "THICC"

Proto-Uralic

***sake**

thick

dense

PY

***qogʌ < *qagʌ**

thick (viscous)

Proto-Finno-Permic

***šiketä**

thick, dense

sound (of sleep)

PKY

***qoj**

thick (said of liquids)

sound (of sleep)

Proto-Finnic

***tihadä**

thick

dense

Proto-Yukaghir

***toyo-/*tonqə-**

thick

dense

sound (of sleep)

Tungusic

***tekti**

thick (of liquids)

Finnish

***suurustaa**

cooking

to thicken

e.g. with flour or cream

PKY

***qoj-qan**

to become thick (said of liquid)

Group “IRATE”

Proto-Uralic *kojwa birch	PY *qwaʹj birch bark
Finnish raivo fury rage wrath	PY *qʌjbes be angry
Finnish raivostuttaa to make someone furious	PY *qʌjbesqʌti to annoy to make somebody angry
Finnish tuhtua to get worked up to get irritated to get indignant	Ket qʌjatʌ mat of birch bark
Finnish tuohi birch bark	Ket qʌjatʌ mat of birch bark

Group “IAMSOGOOD”

Finnish pöyheä fluffy airy	PKY pʰuŋbes to swell
Finnish pöyhkeä haughty uppity snooty	PKY pʰuŋtiu:ŋ splendid luxuriant

Group

“SORRYPROTOGERMANSITISACTUALLYFROM:_PREGREEK_HMM_HEY_WTF!?!?”

Proto-Finnic *kauppa trade commerce goods merchandise	PY *qʌpʰʌ / *qʌpʰʌ trade to trade to sell
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(I spoiled this in the beginning... remember? Older than... but there is more to follow. Soon.)